



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

akāmataḥ kṛte pāpe prāyaścittaṃ vidur budhāḥ | 11.45a[44Ma]

kāmakāraḥ kṛte 'py āhur eke śrutinidarśanāt || 45 || 11.45c[44Mc]

— Manusmṛti, 11.1.3. Justification for Penance (Chapter 3), Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

This verse from the Manusmṛti delves into the complex subject of atonement and the differing perspectives on how we address our wrongdoings. It speaks of 'prāyaścitta', penance or expiation, as a remedy for 'pāpe', sin or wrongdoing. The verse differentiates between actions committed unintentionally ('akāmataḥ kṛte pāpe') and those done deliberately, with conscious desire or intent ('kāmakāraḥ kṛte'). The wise ('budhāḥ') prescribe penance for unintentional transgressions.

However, the verse then adds a layer of nuance. It acknowledges that some, guided by the 'śrutinidarśanāt' (teachings of the Vedas), suggest that penance is also applicable even when the sin is committed knowingly. This highlights a divergence of opinion within the ancient legal and spiritual framework. It suggests that the possibility of redemption remains open, even when we stumble consciously.

The implication for your life is profound. It encourages self-reflection on the nature of your actions and intentions. When you err unintentionally, the path to reconciliation is clear: acknowledge the mistake, make amends, and learn from the experience. But what about those times when you knowingly stray from your ethical compass?

Here, the Manusmṛti, through the voices of those who draw upon the Vedas, offers a message of hope. Even in moments of conscious lapse, the possibility of healing and spiritual growth through penance remains. This penance isn't necessarily about harsh self-punishment, but rather a sincere commitment to change, a willingness to confront the underlying motivations behind your actions, and a dedication to aligning yourself with your values. It calls you to consider the intention behind your actions, and even when that intention is flawed, to strive for self-improvement and make amends for the harm caused. It reminds you that the journey of spiritual evolution is not about perfection, but about continuous learning and growth.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

Given that the Manusmṛti suggests atonement even for intentional wrongdoings, how can you use this understanding to foster compassion for yourself and others, recognizing the potential for growth even in the face of mistakes?